ROADMAN CYCLING

FASTER AFTER 40

What World Tour Coaches Actually Prescribe to Riders Your Age

A Roadman Cycling Report by Anthony Walsh

roadmancycling.com

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"Cycling is hard, our podcast will help."

INTRODUCTION

You're not new to the bike. You train. You've done the hard work. You've ridden through winter, pinned on numbers at local crits, maybe ticked off a sportive that scared you a little. And yet somewhere in the last year or two, the gains have stalled. The watts per kilo haven't moved. The group ride that used to feel comfortable now feels like hanging on. Your body doesn't recover the way it did at thirty.

So you go looking for answers. The cycling internet gives you a thousand of them — most of them generic, most of them contradictory, and almost none of them written for someone your age with your commitments. You've got a career. A family. Maybe a mortgage that won't pay itself. Eight to twelve hours a week on the bike is the ceiling, and some weeks it's more like six.

This report is different. Over the last three years, I've sat across from some of the best coaches in professional cycling — people like Professor Stephen Seiler, Dan Lorang, Dr David Dunne, John Wakefield — and asked them one question over and over again: *What would you prescribe to a serious amateur rider over forty?*

Their answers surprised me. Not because the science was complex — it wasn't. But because the gap between what the internet recommends and what these coaches actually prescribe is enormous. The training, the nutrition, the recovery, the strength work — the best in the world are doing it differently. And almost none of it is complicated. Most of it is fixable.

What follows is everything I've learned, distilled into five pillars: coaching, nutrition, strength and conditioning, recovery, and community. These are the same pillars we use inside **Not Done Yet**, the Roadman Cycling programme for riders who refuse to accept that their best days are behind them.

WHO THIS REPORT IS FOR

You're somewhere between thirty-five and fifty-five. You ride seriously — not as a professional, but seriously enough that it matters to you. You've probably done an Etape, a Marmotte, a Fred Whitton, or something equally painful that you keep going back to. You own a power meter. You know what FTP stands for. You might even know yours to the nearest watt.

You have a demanding job — the kind where stress follows you home. You fit training around family, work, and the hundred small obligations that fill every week. And you've started to notice that the approach which worked at thirty-two doesn't work at forty-four. The same volume, the same intensity, the same routine — but the results have flatlined or, worse, they're going backwards.

This report isn't a training plan. It's a framework. It's the thinking behind the plan — the principles that should inform every decision you make about training, eating, recovering, and showing up. Get these right and any decent plan will work for you. Get them wrong and no plan on earth will save you.

You don't need more volume. You don't need a new bike. You need the right information, applied consistently, by someone who actually understands what it's like to train around a full life.

Here's the good news: it's all fixable.

HOW TO USE THIS REPORT

Each chapter covers one of the five pillars: coaching, nutrition, strength and conditioning, recovery, and community. They're designed to be read in order but each stands alone. If you're already solid on nutrition but your S&C; is non-existent, skip to Chapter 3. If recovery is the weak link, Chapter 4 is where you need to be.

At the end of each chapter, you'll find a call to action for Not Done Yet — the Roadman Cycling programme where we put all of this into practice. Read the report first. Apply what you can on your own. And when you're ready for the structure, the accountability, and the community to make it stick, you know where to find us.

One more thing. Everything in this report comes from conversations with real coaches, real scientists, and real riders. I'll name them throughout — Professor Seiler, Dan Lorang, John Wakefield, Dr David Dunne, Lachlan Morton, and others. These aren't anonymous 'experts.' They're specific people with track records you can verify, and most of them have been on the Roadman Cycling Podcast if you want to hear them in their own words.

— Anthony Walsh, Roadman Cycling

CHAPTER 1

COACHING

The Training Most Masters Riders Get Wrong

THE 80/20 PROBLEM

Here's what nobody tells you about professional cyclists. They spend roughly eighty per cent of their training time riding at a pace so slow that a recreational rider could sit on their wheel. Maybe even ride past them on the bike path. It sounds absurd until you understand why.

Professor Stephen Seiler — the man who essentially created the research framework for polarised training — showed that elite endurance athletes across every sport follow the same pattern: roughly eighty per cent of training at low intensity, roughly twenty per cent at high intensity, and almost nothing in between.

The middle zone — the grey zone — is where most amateur cyclists live. Too hard to be truly easy. Too easy to be truly hard. It's the intensity that feels like training but doesn't produce adaptation. When I had Seiler on the podcast, he put it simply: most age-group riders are riding about fifty per cent too hard when they think they're riding easy.

The ego problem is real. Riding slowly feels like you're not doing anything. Your mates pass you. Your Strava looks embarrassing. But the physiology doesn't care about your ego. Zone 2 riding — proper Zone 2, not 'I can still hold a conversation if I really try' Zone 2 — builds mitochondrial density, improves fat oxidation, and expands your aerobic base. That base is everything after forty. Without it, the high-intensity work has nowhere to land.

If you change nothing else from reading this report, change this: make your easy days properly easy. Drop the pace until it feels almost embarrassingly slow. Then stay there.

HOW TO KNOW YOU'RE ACTUALLY IN ZONE 2

The simplest test is the talk test — but not the version most people use. True Zone 2 means you can hold a full conversation in complete sentences without needing to pause for breath mid-thought. If you're speaking in fragments between breaths, you're above Zone 2. If you could recite a poem, you're about right.

With a heart rate monitor, Zone 2 typically falls between 60 and 75 per cent of your maximum heart rate, depending on your individual physiology. With a power meter, it's roughly 55 to 75 per cent of FTP. The exact numbers vary — what matters is the intent. Easy means easy. If it feels like work, it's not Zone 2.

TrainingPeaks can help you track your intensity distribution across a training block. Look at the percentage of time you spend in each zone over a month. If your Zone 2 percentage is below seventy per cent of your total volume, you're almost certainly spending too much time in the grey zone. Most riders who audit this honestly are shocked by the results.

LOW-CADENCE TORQUE INTERVALS: THE SESSION THE PROS NEVER STOPPED DOING

For years, the cycling internet told you that low-cadence work was a waste of time. Forum posts, Reddit threads, even some coaching platforms repeated the same line: cadence doesn't matter, just ride at your natural preference. The coaches knew this was wrong. So they kept prescribing these sessions anyway and waited for the science to catch up.

In 2024, it did. Raphael and Paulina Habis at Rocklaw University in Poland published a study in *PLOS ONE* that finally confirmed what coaches like John Wakefield and Tim Kerrison had known for years. The results were stark: the low-cadence interval group improved VO_2max by 8.7 per cent versus 4.6 per cent for the freely chosen cadence group. Maximum aerobic power was up 8.1 per cent versus 3 per cent. Same sessions, same effort, nearly double the results. The only difference: one number on their bike computer screen.

Why does it work? Three reasons.

Muscle fibre recruitment. Grinding a big gear at low cadence forces your Type II (fast-twitch) muscle fibres to work at aerobic intensities. Over time, those fibres develop more mitochondria and greater oxidative capacity. You're effectively converting raw power fibres into endurance fibres.

Neuromuscular development. Your brain learns to recruit more muscle fibres per pedal stroke. Each revolution produces more force with less perceived effort.

Aerobic expansion without volume. This is the critical one for time-crunched riders. You can expand your aerobic engine without adding hours to the training week. For someone fitting sessions around a career and a family, that's the difference between a programme that works and one that falls apart by February.

SESSION 1: TORQUE INTERVALS ON A CLIMB (from John Wakefield, Bora-Hansgrohe)

Find a climb of 4–7% gradient, steady, no traffic lights.
4 x 4 minutes at 40–60 RPM, RPE 7/10.
Stay seated. Big gear. Smooth pedal stroke.
4 minutes easy spinning recovery between reps.
Total session time: ~45 minutes including warm-up and cool-down.

SESSION 2: SUSTAINED TORQUE ON FLAT/ROLLING TERRAIN

3 x 8–12 minutes at 50–65 RPM, steady effort.
RPE 6–7/10. This should feel muscularly hard, not cardiovascularly.
5 minutes easy spinning between reps.
Good for flat courses or indoor trainers.

THE SCIENCE THE INTERNET GOT WRONG

Previous studies that dismissed low-cadence work were fundamentally flawed. Christopherson in 2014, Nimmer in 2012, Luda and Witty in 2016 — they all tested the wrong protocols. Too short, too light, wrong cadence ranges. It was like testing whether weightlifting works by handing someone a two-kilogram dumbbell and measuring their strength gains after a fortnight. The Habis study used protocols that actually reflected what coaches were prescribing in the real world — and the results were unambiguous.

This matters because it illustrates a broader point about cycling advice. For years, the internet obsessed over the idea that science trumps coaching experience. In many cases, that's absolutely right — we should demand evidence. But what the Habis study shows is something the best coaches have always understood: sometimes the science takes a while to catch up to what works in practice.

PERIODISATION FOR THE TIME-CRUNCHED RIDER

When I had Joe Friel on the podcast, he made a point that stuck with me: most amateur cyclists don't periodise at all. They do the same training week, month after month, year after year. Same Tuesday chain gang. Same Saturday sportive loop. Same intensity, same duration, same results — which is to say, diminishing results.

Periodisation doesn't require a sports science degree. At its simplest, it means organising your training into blocks with distinct purposes: a base phase where volume is higher and intensity is low; a build phase where intensity increases and volume drops slightly; a peak phase where you sharpen for your target event; and a recovery phase where you actually let your body absorb the work.

For masters riders with limited hours, the three-week-on, one-week-off rhythm works well. Three weeks of progressive load — each week slightly harder than the last — followed by a recovery week at sixty to seventy per cent of normal volume. Your body adapts during recovery, not during training. Skip the recovery week and you're just accumulating fatigue.

The riders who improve fastest aren't the ones training the most. They're the ones training with structure, purpose, and enough discipline to rest when the programme says rest.

SAMPLE BUILD-PHASE WEEK (8-10 HOURS AVAILABLE)

Monday: Rest or 30-min S&C session
Tuesday: 75 min — 20-min warm-up, torque intervals (4x4 min), cool-down
Wednesday: 60-90 min Zone 2 (properly easy, talk-test pace)
Thursday: 30-min S&C session
Friday: Rest or easy 45-min spin
Saturday: 2.5-3 hr Zone 2 endurance ride with cafe stop
Sunday: 90 min — 15-min warm-up, 3x10 min sweet spot, cool-down

THE MENTAL GAME ON CLIMBS

While we're talking about coaching, I want to address something most training plans ignore entirely: the mental side of climbing. It's the thing most people miss and it's often the fastest way to stop getting dropped.

You know the moment. The road tilts up. You look down at your head unit and those little red gradients appear ahead. Your heart rate spikes — not from the effort, but from the anticipation. You start riding above your threshold before the climb has even begun, burning matches you'll need later.

Bradley Wiggins once said something that changed how I think about climbing: 'He used to ride the climb rather than ride against his rivals.' That distinction matters. When you ride against other people, you pace off them. When you ride the climb, you pace off yourself. You find your rhythm, hold your effort, and let the gradient dictate the speed — not your ego.

There's no point in following someone up at their pace if it means you blow up at two-thirds distance. Ride your own effort. Concentrate on your own numbers. The riders who went past you at the bottom? Half of them will be coming back to you before the top.

THIS IS EXACTLY WHAT WE BUILD FOR RIDERS INSIDE NOT DONE YET

Structured training, periodised to your life, informed by the coaches behind Grand Tour wins. Not a template. A system that adapts to you.

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CHAPTER 2

NUTRITION

Eat More, Weigh Less, Ride Faster

WHY 'CALORIES IN VS CALORIES OUT' IS FAILING YOU

The cycling internet is going to tell you that weight loss is simple. Calories in versus calories out. Burn more than you eat. Ride more. Eat less. This advice is so outdated it's not just incomplete — it's actively making things worse.

Here's what actually happens when a forty-five-year-old cyclist follows the 'eat less, ride more' playbook. You cut calories. Your body interprets this as a threat. Cortisol rises. Testosterone drops. Your metabolism slows to protect itself. You lose weight initially — mostly water and muscle glycogen — then plateau. You're now riding on less fuel, recovering more slowly, and your power numbers start to slide. So you cut more. And the cycle continues until you're exhausted, underfuelled, and weaker than when you started.

The coaches I've spoken to — people working with professional riders whose body composition is their livelihood — take the opposite approach. They fuel performance first and let body composition follow.

THE HORMONAL REALITY AFTER FORTY

Here's where it gets really interesting — and where the 'just eat less' crowd completely lose the plot. After forty, your hormonal environment shifts. Testosterone declines by roughly one to two per cent per year. Cortisol sensitivity increases. Insulin response changes. These aren't small, abstract numbers — they directly affect how your body partitions fuel between muscle and fat.

Calorie restriction in this hormonal environment is like trying to fight a fire with petrol. You trigger a stress response that amplifies the very hormonal patterns working against you. Cortisol rises further, testosterone drops further, and your body preferentially stores fat and burns muscle. The exact opposite of what you want.

The coaches who work with masters athletes understand this. They don't start with a calorie target. They start with food quality, meal timing, and adequate protein — and let the body composition follow. It takes longer than a crash diet. It also actually works.

86 TO 79 KG IN TWELVE WEEKS — WHILE EATING MORE

I want to share something personal because I think it illustrates the point better than any study could. I lost seven kilograms in twelve weeks. I went from 86 to 79 kg. And I did it while eating more food than I'd ever eaten in my life.

What I didn't do was download MyFitnessPal and start tracking calories. What I didn't do was skip meals. What I didn't do was go on fasted rides and bonk sixty kilometres from home. I didn't do any of that.

What I did was eat properly. Quality food, at the right times, in quantities that matched my training load. I fuelled my rides. I ate protein at every meal. I stopped arriving home from a four-hour ride so glycogen-depleted that I'd inhale a packet of biscuits and a bowl of cereal at 9 pm. My power didn't drop. My energy went up. And the weight came off steadily, sustainably, without ever feeling like I was on a diet.

PROTEIN: THE MOST UNDERRATED TOOL FOR MASTERS CYCLISTS

After forty, your body becomes less efficient at muscle protein synthesis. The scientific term is anabolic resistance — your muscles need a stronger stimulus and more protein to maintain and build tissue compared to when you were twenty-five. This isn't a small effect. It's significant enough that the protein guidelines most cyclists follow (the generic '0.8g per kg' recommendation) are almost certainly too low.

Current sports nutrition research suggests masters endurance athletes need 1.4 to 1.8 grams of protein per kilogram of bodyweight per day, distributed across three to four meals. For a 78 kg rider, that's roughly 110 to 140 grams daily — substantially more than most cyclists consume.

Timing matters too. There's strong evidence that protein before bed stimulates overnight muscle protein synthesis. A recent study showed that cyclists who consumed 30 to 40 grams of casein protein before sleep built muscle faster than those who didn't, without any change to their training. It's a small adjustment with a measurable return.

IN-RIDE FUELLING: WHAT THE PROS ACTUALLY CONSUME

Professional cyclists now consume 90 to 120 grams of carbohydrate per hour during hard racing. Ten years ago, the recommendation was 60 grams. The science has finally caught up, and the performance difference is enormous.

You don't need to match pro-level intake on a Sunday club ride. But most amateurs are dramatically underfuelling their harder sessions and events. A general starting point for rides over ninety minutes: aim for 60 to 80 grams of carbohydrate per hour using a mix of glucose and fructose (the dual-transport approach your gut absorbs most efficiently). Energy gels, rice cakes, dates, bananas — the specific food matters less than the quantity and consistency.

The riders who fuel properly can train harder, recover faster, and maintain body composition more easily than those who restrict. It sounds counterintuitive, but eating more on the bike often leads to eating less off it — because you're not arriving home in a state of desperate glycogen depletion.

GUT TRAINING: THE BIT NOBODY MENTIONS

If you've been underfuelling on rides for years, you can't suddenly start consuming 80 grams of carbohydrate per hour without your stomach protesting. The gut is trainable — just like your legs. Start at 40 grams per hour and increase by 10 grams each week. Within a month, your gut will tolerate quantities that would have wrecked you before. Professional teams build gut training into their periodisation. It's not an afterthought — it's a deliberate part of race preparation.

A SIMPLE FUELLING FRAMEWORK FOR TRAINING RIDES

Under 60 minutes: Water only. No fuel needed.
60-90 minutes: One bottle with electrolytes. One gel or banana if high intensity.
90 minutes to 3 hours: 60g carbs/hour. Mix of gels, bars, real food.
3+ hours: 60-80g carbs/hour. Start eating early (within first 30 min).
Post-ride: Protein-rich meal within 60 minutes. 30g+ protein minimum.

BODY COMPOSITION VS SCALE WEIGHT

The number on the scales is the least useful metric in cycling. Two riders can weigh the same and have wildly different power-to-weight ratios depending on their body composition. A kilogram of muscle produces watts. A kilogram of fat doesn't.

What matters is lean mass relative to total weight — and for masters cyclists, preserving lean mass is the priority. Crash diets strip muscle. Proper fuelling combined with strength work (more on this in Chapter 3) preserves muscle while reducing body fat. The scale might not move dramatically, but the power-to-weight ratio shifts in the right direction.

Track trends over weeks and months, not daily fluctuations. If you must weigh yourself, do it once a week, same time, same conditions. Better yet, use how your clothes fit and how you feel on the bike as your primary feedback.

CHAPTER 3

STRENGTH & CONDITIONING

The Non-Negotiable You Keep Skipping

WHY S&C; IS NON-NEGOTIABLE AFTER FORTY

Here's the thing nobody tells you about ageing and cycling. After thirty-five, you lose roughly three to five per cent of your muscle mass per decade if you're not actively working to maintain it. The clinical term is sarcopenia, and it's not something that happens to sedentary people only. Cyclists are especially vulnerable because the sport is almost entirely concentric — pushing, never pulling — and non-weight-bearing.

What this means in practice: your power drops. Your bone density decreases (cyclists already have notoriously poor bone density compared to runners and team-sport athletes). Your injury risk climbs. That lower back pain after three hours in the saddle? That hip tightness? That knee that flares up every March? Most of it traces back to muscular weakness and imbalance that the bike alone cannot fix.

Every coach I've spoken to — every single one — prescribes strength work for their masters riders. It's not optional. It's not a nice-to-have. It is the single most impactful change most over-forty cyclists can make outside of their actual riding.

THE RIGHT EXERCISES FOR CYCLISTS OVER FORTY

You don't need a gym membership. You don't need heavy barbells. What you need are movements that build single-leg stability, core strength, hip mobility, and posterior chain resilience — the areas cycling neglects most.

The programme should centre on bodyweight, dumbbell, and resistance band work. The focus is functional strength that transfers to the bike, not bodybuilding aesthetics. Here are the key movement patterns:

Single-leg work (addresses the bilateral deficit cyclists develop):

Split squats, Bulgarian split squats, lunges (forward, reverse, and lateral), step-ups onto a bench or box. Start with bodyweight, progress to holding dumbbells. Three sets of eight to twelve reps per leg. These build the single-leg stability that directly transfers to pedalling force — because cycling is, at its core, a single-leg sport.

Hip and glute activation (the powerhouse of the pedal stroke):

Hip bridges (single and double leg), clamshells with a resistance band, goblet squats with a dumbbell held at chest height, lateral band walks. Your glutes are the biggest muscles involved in cycling and the most commonly underactivated. If your quads burn before anything else on a climb, your glutes aren't doing their job.

Core stability (not six-pack work — functional core):

Front planks, side planks, dead bugs, pallof presses with a band. The core's job on the bike is to provide a stable platform for your legs to push against. A weak core means energy leaks with every pedal stroke — small losses that add up to minutes on every meaningful ascent.

Hip mobility and flexibility (counteracting the cycling position):

Hip flexor stretches, pigeon pose, thoracic spine rotations, hamstring work with a band. Cycling locks your hips in flexion for hours. If you're not actively counteracting this, your hip flexors shorten, your lower back compensates, and eventually something gives.

THE BONE DENSITY PROBLEM NOBODY TALKS ABOUT

Cyclists have some of the worst bone density scores of any athletic population. The sport is non-weight-bearing — your skeleton never gets the impact loading that stimulates bone remodelling. A 2019 review found that competitive male cyclists had lower bone mineral density than age-matched sedentary controls in some studies. Read that again: in some cases, doing nothing was better for your bones than cycling.

After forty, this matters more than ever. Bone density naturally declines with age. Combine that age-related decline with a sport that provides zero weight-bearing stimulus, and you have a recipe for stress fractures, particularly in the hip, spine, and pelvis. A fall that a twenty-five-year-old rugby player would walk away from could mean a broken hip for a fifty-year-old cyclist.

Strength training — particularly loaded exercises like step-ups, lunges, and goblet squats — provides exactly the stimulus your bones need. It's not just about muscles. It's about keeping your skeleton robust enough to handle the sport safely for another twenty years.

PROGRESSION: HOW TO GET STRONGER WITHOUT GETTING HURT

The most common mistake is starting too heavy, too fast. If you haven't done structured strength work before, your tendons, ligaments, and connective tissue need time to adapt — even if your muscles feel ready for more. Tendons adapt roughly four to six times slower than muscles. Respect that timeline.

Start with bodyweight only for the first two to three weeks. Master the movement pattern before adding load. When you do add weight, increase by no more than five to ten per cent per week. If a movement causes pain (not discomfort — actual pain), stop. Reduce the load or swap to a regression.

A sensible twelve-week progression looks like this: weeks one to three, bodyweight only, learning form. Weeks four to eight, light dumbbells (5-10 kg), increasing reps from eight to twelve. Weeks nine to twelve, moderate dumbbells (10-15 kg), introducing more challenging variations like Bulgarian split squats and single-leg Romanian deadlifts.

FITTING TWO SESSIONS INTO YOUR WEEK

Two sessions per week. Thirty minutes each. That's all it takes. Not two hours in a gym. Not a CrossFit class. Thirty focused minutes with the right movements.

SAMPLE WEEKLY S&C SCHEDULE

Monday (after an easy ride or rest day): Lower body focus
— Split squats 3x10, hip bridges 3x12, goblet squats 3x10, clamshells 2x15
Thursday (after an easy ride): Upper body + core focus
— Press-ups 3x12, single-arm rows 3x10, front plank 3x30s, dead bugs 3x10
Each session: 30 minutes including a 5-minute warm-up
Avoid S&C on the same day as your hard interval sessions.

Place your S&C; sessions on easy days or rest days, never on the same day as your key interval work. The S&C; supports the cycling; it shouldn't compete with it. If you're choosing between a strength session and a sixth hour on the bike, the strength session will almost always give you more return per minute invested.

CHAPTER 4

RECOVERY

The Hours That Actually Build Fitness

SLEEP: YOUR PRIMARY RECOVERY TOOL

If you want one free performance upgrade that requires zero talent and zero training time, it's sleep. The research is overwhelming: athletes who consistently sleep seven to nine hours per night show measurably better endurance, faster reaction times, lower injury rates, and improved body composition compared to those who sleep six hours or fewer.

For masters athletes, sleep is even more critical. Growth hormone — essential for muscle repair and adaptation — is released primarily during deep sleep. Testosterone, which supports recovery and muscle maintenance, follows the same pattern. Cut your sleep short and you're cutting short the hormonal environment your body needs to adapt to training.

The practical advice is simple but rarely followed. Consistent bed and wake times — even on weekends. A cool, dark room. No screens for thirty minutes before bed (the blue light suppresses melatonin production). Limit caffeine after midday. If you train in the evening, allow at least two hours between finishing a hard session and going to bed.

I know this sounds basic. But when I ask riders in the Not Done Yet community to honestly audit their sleep, the numbers are almost always worse than they expect. Six hours and fifteen minutes is the average self-reported figure. That's not enough.

SLEEP AND PERFORMANCE: THE NUMBERS

A Stanford study on elite athletes found that extending sleep to eight to ten hours per night improved sprint times, reaction accuracy, and subjective wellbeing by statistically significant margins. Conversely, restricting sleep to six hours or fewer for just four consecutive nights reduced maximal strength by up to nine per cent and time to exhaustion by over ten per cent.

For a masters cyclist, the implications are direct. That Tuesday evening interval session after a poor night's sleep isn't just unpleasant — it's physiologically less effective. You're producing less power, your perceived effort is higher, your recovery cost is greater, and the adaptation stimulus is weaker. You'd have been better off doing a Zone 2 spin or, on some occasions, staying on the sofa entirely.

The most underrated sleep intervention isn't a supplement or a gadget. It's consistency. Going to bed and waking up at the same time — even on weekends — regulates your circadian rhythm more effectively than any sleeping aid. It takes about two weeks to establish, and most riders who commit to it report measurably better energy and training quality.

HRV MONITORING AND READINESS

Heart rate variability — the variation in time between each heartbeat — has become one of the most useful tools for tracking recovery and readiness in endurance athletes. Higher HRV generally indicates a well-recovered, parasympathetically dominant state. Lower HRV suggests accumulated stress, fatigue, or illness.

Professional teams use HRV data to make daily training decisions. Dan Lorang, Head of Performance at Red Bull–Bora–Hansgrohe, has spoken about using morning HRV readings alongside subjective questionnaires to determine whether a rider trains as planned, modifies the session, or rests entirely. The approach is data-informed, not data-dictated. The number tells you something. It doesn't tell you everything.

For amateur riders, the key is consistency of measurement. Use the same device, same time of day (ideally first thing in the morning, lying down, before coffee), and track trends over weeks rather than reacting to individual readings. A single low HRV reading doesn't mean you're ill. A sustained downward trend over five to seven days means your body is telling you something worth listening to.

Apps like HRV4Training or the readiness features on Garmin and Whoop devices make this accessible. You don't need a lab. You need a morning routine and the discipline to actually act on what the data shows you — which, for most riders, means resting more often than they'd like.

STRESS: THE OVERLOOKED PERFORMANCE KILLER

Your body doesn't distinguish between physical stress and psychological stress. A hard interval session and a brutal day at work produce the same cortisol response. The same inflammatory markers rise. The same recovery resources get depleted.

This is the part that most training plans completely ignore, and it's the part that matters most for the typical Roadman listener — a professional in their late thirties to mid-fifties with a demanding career, a family, financial responsibilities, and maybe a parent who needs care. You're not a twenty-three-year-old neo-pro whose only job is to train and recover. You carry stress that no periodisation plan accounts for.

The practical implication: on weeks when life stress is high, you need to reduce training stress. Not because you're being soft. Because the total allostatic load — the combined burden of all stressors — determines whether your body adapts or breaks down. A coach who only looks at your TrainingPeaks data without knowing about your work deadline or your lack of sleep is working with half the picture.

PRACTICAL STRESS MANAGEMENT FOR PROFESSIONALS

I'm not going to tell you to meditate for twenty minutes a day. If you're the type of rider this report is written for, you probably won't. What I will tell you is that the following three things have the greatest impact on stress-related training impairment, according to the coaches I've spoken to:

First, commute by bike when you can. It sounds obvious, but converting a stress-inducing car commute into a Zone 2 ride changes the biochemical signature of your entire day. You arrive at work having already processed cortisol through movement. Dan Lorang has spoken about the value of low-intensity commuting as a recovery tool — it's active recovery that also solves a logistics problem.

Second, protect the hour before bed. No screens, no work email, no financial admin. This is the single most effective intervention for sleep quality, which cascades into every other recovery metric.

Third, track your subjective stress alongside your training. A simple one-to-five rating in your training diary — 'How stressful was today outside of training?' — gives you a retrospective tool to understand why some training blocks produced results and others didn't. Patterns emerge fast.

ACTIVE RECOVERY VS PASSIVE RECOVERY

There's a time for each, and knowing the difference matters.

Active recovery — a properly easy thirty- to forty-five-minute spin, coffee ride pace, heart rate below sixty per cent of max — promotes blood flow to damaged muscles without adding meaningful training stress. It's useful the day after a hard session or a race. The key word is *easy*. If you turn a recovery ride into a chain gang, you've defeated the purpose.

Passive recovery — doing nothing, or at most some gentle stretching or a walk — is appropriate when you're deeply fatigued, fighting illness, or carrying accumulated stress from multiple hard days. Complete rest isn't laziness. It's a training decision.

WHEN TO PUSH THROUGH VS WHEN TO REST

This is the question I get asked more than any other, and the real answer is: it depends. But there are signals worth paying attention to.

Push through when: you feel flat in the first ten minutes but your heart rate responds normally, your legs warm up after the initial heaviness, and your mood lifts once you're moving. Most of the time, you'll feel better thirty minutes in than you did on the turbo at minute one.

Back off when: your resting heart rate is elevated by more than five beats above normal, your HRV has been suppressed for three or more consecutive days, you're fighting a sore throat or feel a cold coming on, or you've had fewer than six hours of sleep for two nights running. Training in this state doesn't build fitness. It digs the hole deeper.

The riders who improve year on year are the ones who learn to distinguish between 'I don't feel like it' and 'my body is telling me something.' One is laziness. The other is wisdom.

CHAPTER 5

COMMUNITY

Le Métier — The Craft of Being a Cyclist

THE CRAFT

The French have a word for it: *le métier*. It translates loosely as 'the craft' or 'the trade' — but in cycling, it means something more specific. It's the accumulated knowledge of how to be a cyclist. How to ride in a group. How to read a race. How to eat, rest, suffer, and recover. The unwritten rules. The culture. The way you conduct yourself on the road.

Professional cyclists learn *le métier* by osmosis — years in the peloton, mentored by older riders, absorbing knowledge through proximity. When I spoke to Michael Matthews about his fifteen-plus years in the professional peloton, he talked about how much of what he knows was never taught formally. It was absorbed. Picked up from room-mates at races, from team buses, from suffering alongside people who'd been doing it longer.

Amateur cyclists don't get that. You ride alone or in a loose club group. You absorb advice from the internet, which is contradictory at best and harmful at worst. There's no structure for learning the craft. No community of people who are trying to do the same thing you're doing, at the same level, with the same constraints.

That's what we built Not Done Yet to fix.

ACCOUNTABILITY AND CONSISTENCY

The single biggest predictor of improvement in amateur cycling isn't talent, genetics, or equipment. It's consistency. And the single biggest driver of consistency is accountability.

Training alone, it's easy to skip a session when work runs late or the weather's grim or you're just not feeling it. Nobody notices. Nobody asks where you were. The programme drifts. Three skipped sessions become a skipped week. A skipped week becomes a lost month. By April you're starting your 'season' from scratch again.

Inside NDY, riders post their sessions, share their struggles, and hold each other to account. Not in a punitive way — nobody's shouting at you for missing a Tuesday ride. But there's something powerful about knowing that a group of people in the same boat are watching, encouraging, and expecting you to show up. It changes behaviour in a way that a training plan on a screen never can.

THE 'NOT DONE YET' IDENTITY

The name matters. 'Not Done Yet' isn't a tagline. It's a statement about who you are.

You're the rider who's been told — by your body, by your age, by the little voice in the back of your head — that the fast days are over. That you should be grateful for what you've done and accept the decline gracefully. That forty-five or fifty or fifty-five means slowing down.

You don't accept that. You refuse to. There's more in you, and you know it. What's been missing isn't motivation — you've got that in spades. What's been missing is the right system, the right information, and the right people around you.

THE NDY WEEKLY RHYTHM

Structure creates freedom. Inside Not Done Yet, the week has a rhythm that keeps riders engaged without overwhelming them. Weekly live calls with me where we discuss training, nutrition, and whatever's on members' minds. A shared training log where riders post their sessions — not for validation, but for accountability. Regular 'Coffee Time' check-ins where the community connects over something simpler than watts and kilojoules.

The format matters because most online communities die within three months. They launch with energy, fill up with introductions, then slowly go quiet as members drift away. NDY doesn't have that problem because the structure demands participation — gently, consistently, weekly. When someone goes quiet for a fortnight, people notice. They reach out. Not to guilt-trip. To check in.

When I spoke to Lachlan Morton about his years in professional cycling — the team camps, the races, the suffering alongside people who understood exactly what he was going through — he talked about the importance of shared experience. Not shared knowledge. Shared *experience*. Training alone, you have knowledge. Training inside a community, you have experience. The difference is what keeps you going when motivation drops.

THE INFORMATION VS APPLICATION GAP

You probably already know most of what's in this report. Seriously. If you've been listening to the podcast for any length of time, none of the science will be new to you. Polarised training. Protein timing. S&C; twice a week. Sleep more. You've heard it all.

So why haven't the results changed?

Because information without application is entertainment. You can listen to a hundred podcast episodes about low-cadence torque intervals and never actually do one. You can know exactly how much protein you should eat and still reach for the biscuit tin at 9 pm. You can understand periodisation perfectly and still do the same chain gang every Tuesday for three years.

The gap between knowing and doing is where most riders live. It's comfortable. It feels productive. But it doesn't produce results. Closing that gap requires something beyond information — it requires structure, accountability, and the presence of other people who expect you to follow through.

WHAT HAPPENS WHEN THE SYSTEM WORKS

A few examples from inside the community (details anonymised for privacy):

Rider A, 44, London. Joined as a Category 3 racer with an FTP that hadn't moved in two years. After six months of structured training, nutrition adjustment, and adding two S&C; sessions per week, he raced to a Category 1 upgrade. Same training hours. Different structure.

Rider B, 51, Dublin. Came in at 20 per cent body fat, frustrated, considering giving up racing entirely. Twelve months later: 7 per cent body fat, a 28-watt FTP increase, and a finish at the Women's National Series that surprised everyone — most of all, herself.

Rider C, 47, Manchester. Classic 'podcast loyalist' — listened to every episode but never applied any of it. Joined NDY, committed to the programme, and within three months had set a personal best on a climb he'd ridden two hundred times. His words: 'I knew all of this already. I just needed someone to make me actually do it.'

These aren't outliers. They're the pattern. Structure, accountability, and the right information — applied consistently, inside a community that expects you to show up.

APPLY FOR NOT DONE YET — $195/MONTH

Weekly live calls with Anthony. Structured training. S&C roadmap. Nutrition frameworks. A private community of serious cyclists who refuse to accept the plateau. You're not done yet.

Apply now: https://www.skool.com/roadmancycling

WHAT COMES NEXT

You've just read five chapters covering the same principles that inform training at the highest level of professional cycling — adapted for riders who train around careers, families, and real life. Coaching, nutrition, strength, recovery, and community. The five pillars.

Some of you will take this report and run with it. You'll restructure your training week, add the torque intervals, fix your protein intake, start the S&C; work, and protect your sleep. You'll see results — real, measurable results — within eight to twelve weeks. And that's brilliant. That's the whole point of writing this.

But some of you — and you know who you are — will read this, nod along, save the PDF somewhere sensible, and then do exactly what you were doing before. Not because you lack motivation. Not because you doubt the science. But because applying this stuff consistently, week after week, month after month, without structure and accountability, is brutally hard.

That's what Not Done Yet exists to solve.

WHAT NDY ACTUALLY LOOKS LIKE

Not Done Yet is the Roadman Cycling programme for serious amateur cyclists who refuse to accept that their best days are behind them. It costs $195 per month. There's no contract, no lock-in, no hidden fees. You stay because it works, or you leave.

Here's what's inside:

Weekly live calls with me. Not pre-recorded webinars. Live, interactive sessions where you can ask questions, share what's working, and get direct feedback. The sessions are recorded if you can't make it live.

Structured training frameworks. Periodised, evidence-based, informed by conversations with World Tour coaches. Not a one-size-fits-all template — a system that adapts to your available hours, your goals, and your life.

A complete S&C; roadmap. Every exercise demonstrated, every progression planned. Designed specifically for cyclists, with the movements that matter and none that don't.

Nutrition frameworks. Not meal plans. Frameworks that teach you how to fuel properly for your training load — so you can make good decisions on your own, not follow a rigid list that falls apart on a busy week.

A private community of serious riders. Not a Facebook group full of beginners. A curated community of cyclists who train hard, show up consistently, and hold each other to account. These are people like you — professionals, parents, riders who fit it all in around demanding lives.

Access to the experts. The coaches, the scientists, the riders I've spent years building relationships with — their insights flow into the programme continuously. You get the benefit of that access without needing to track them down yourself.

If you're ready, the application is at **https://www.skool.com/roadmancycling**.

If you're not ready yet, that's fine too. Keep the report. Apply what you can. And when the time comes — when you've had enough of guessing, enough of doing it alone — we'll be here.

You're not done yet.

READY TO STOP GUESSING?

You've read the report. You've seen what the best coaches prescribe. You know the training, nutrition, strength, and recovery frameworks that separate riders who plateau from riders who keep improving.

The question is whether you'll apply it alone — or inside a system built to make sure you actually do.

NOT DONE YET — $195/MONTH

- Weekly live calls with Anthony
- Structured, periodised training informed by World Tour coaches
- Complete S&C roadmap for cyclists
- Personalised nutrition frameworks
- A private community of serious riders who show up
- Access to the experts, the science, and the system

APPLY NOW

https://www.skool.com/roadmancycling

You're not done yet.